of CM as there was no vacancy of PM", a statement seen as endorsement of Nitish's continuation. As a senior BJP leader admits, "Everyone understands that a part of Nitish's support base among EBCs and women could turn less enthusiastic if the alliance does not speak in one voice."

The NDA is also hitting where it hurts most, with leaders, including Modi and Nitish, relentlessly invoking the old bogey of a return to "jungle raj", shorthand for the alleged decade of lawlessness during his father Lalu and mother Rabri Devi's rule before 2005. To neutralise any inherited guilt from that fiercely contested legacy, Tejashwi turns the lens inward. "I have never harmed anyone. No one has any grievance against me," he says, suggesting he cannot be held responsible for what happened before.

To neutralise criticism of his troubled political legacy, Tejashwi turns the lens inward. "I'll take action even if my shadow is seen to do any harm"

The strategy is deliberate: distancing himself from the troubled baggage of the past without naming it. This election, in many ways, is Tejashwi's attempt to rewrite the RJD's script in his own image. The party today is as much about him, as the socialist, power-to-the-underclasses movement was once about his father. He alone carries the family's electoral torch; no other Yadav from the clan is on the RJD ballot (estranged elder brother Tej Pratap is contesting from his own party). "Tejashwi is asking you for one chance. You gave the NDA 20 years, give me 20 months. Together, we will build a new Bihar," he declares, casting himself as the face of generational change; a man trying to unshackle himself from his father's shadow and Bihar's political fatigue.

ENTER TEJASHWI THE POLITICIAN

The son of Bihar's first couple of politics, Tejashwi grew up in a world where the boundaries between myth and power blurred early. A Class 9-pass, he flirted with professional cricket—even warming the benches for IPL team Delhi Daredevils—before trading it all in for political rallies. Tejashwi's first brush with campaign politics came in 2010, when he accompanied his father to a rally during the Bihar polls—a baptism by fire in an election that proved disastrous for the RJD. He returned to Delhi to pursue cricket, but the family crisis in 2013, when Lalu was convicted in

INTERVIEW

"WE WILL FORM A NEW GOVT FOR A NEW BIHAR"

On October 27, as the campaign for the first phase of the Bihar election wound down, Mahagathbandhan CM candidate Tejashwi Yadav spoke to India Today TV's Marya Shakil on the poll build-up, his counter to the NDA campaign, the poll promises and how he'll fulfil them. Excerpts:

On the NDA campaign: Well, Prime Minister Modi came, Amit Shah came, central ministers are coming, but no one has explained how they will free Bihar from poverty, migration, unemployment...increase Bihar's per capita income, and how, they might take Bihar to among the top states. Even now, they are in the field campaigning, but not a single word is being said about Bihar's progress. In fact, Shah has said factories and industries can't be set up here due to land shortage...he has clearly stated factories and industries can't be set up in Bihar. Also, remember the 2015 election, when PM Modi had promised to make Bihar an IT hub. Ten years have passed, what happened to the IT hub? And now Shah is saying they will build an AI hub. You can't trust these guys, the NDA is just full of rhetoric.

On the big promise: a government job for every family: Experts say that this will inflate Bihar's salary bill to Rs 6 lakh crore (given that there are 25 million families in the state). But then, last time (when Tejashwi was deputy CM in 2023), they had said the same when we talked of creating 1 million jobs. CM Nitish Kumar, too, had asked how he will create the jobs. Today, those same people are talking about 10 million jobs and giving Rs 10,000 as dole to women. We have worked on the jobs issue with experts and will soon present the blueprint, including how we'll generate revenues, to the people of Bihar.

On friendly fights in 10 seats: That is strategic for us. You see, we had friendly fights in Jharkhand too, and in Jammu and Kashmir. This is in keeping with the internal strategy of the Grand Alliance.